

PLANTATION TO TEAPOT

Producing tea is much more than just plucking leaves and drying them. The process involves a series of steps, each of them equally important, which take the leaves from the first plucking stage to the finished product.

Every country and region has a distinct way of producing tea. Handmade teas vary the most, from village to village and from maker to maker. However, there are universally accepted production processes that have been used for

centuries. During the height of tea production in China, India, Japan, and Korea, tea producers work around the clock. There is a very short window for plucking, and once separated from the plant, the leaf starts to degrade.

TEA PRODUCTION PROCESS

Not all tea types go through the same stages of production. Some have lots of steps, such as black and oolong teas, while others, such as yellow tea, have

minimal production. Use the key opposite to find a particular tea type and follow left to right, starting with plucking and moving through the various steps to completion.

PLUCKING

A tea plant is plucked over several growing periods—in early spring (notably in Darjeeling), when the first flush of young buds appear, again in early summer and, in some areas, in fall. In equatorial regions, such as Kenya, tea is plucked year-round. On sloping terrain, tea is still hand-plucked—a laborious task performed mostly by women.

WITHERING

Fresh tea leaves contain 75 percent moisture, which must be removed from the leaves to make them pliable for further processing. Leaves are spread out, either in the sun (white tea, Pu'er), or on trays in a controlled, well-ventilated factory environment where the temperature is kept at 68–75°F (20–24°C). The average wither is 20 hours, but varies from tea to tea.

ROLLING

Now that some of the moisture has left the leaf, the tea juices are more condensed and the leaf is ready to be shaped into rolled, twisted, or curled leaves. This stage breaks down the cell walls in the leaf and sets the leaf up for optimum oxidation for oolong and black teas, and brings the aromatics to the surface for green and yellow teas.

FIXING

This stage applies only to green and yellow tea, which do not go through an intentional factory withering, rather a short air drying to remove moisture. The leaves are “fixed” quickly under high heat to destroy enzymes and prevent oxidation. Fixing, also known as “kill green,” is done by pan-firing. This preserves the aromas and volatile oils in the leaves.